



Lexus LM 350h

PRICE STARTS: ₹2.2 CRORE
ENGINE: 2.5 LITRE PETROL HYBRID
OUTPUT: 190-193 BHP
TORQUE: 240 NM



SUITED EXECUTIVE

STEPS into the captain seat of the tall-roof Toyota Vellfire

multi-purpose vehicle (MPV), folds out the retractable table, plugs a laptop into the HDMI port, and watches a boardroom presentation on the rear screen. While the meeting is on, he picks up the smartphone-like control device on the armrest to switch on the massage function. Outside, Delhi's traffic crawls through honking chaos. Inside, the highly insulated cabin is silent enough for a business meeting. The business promoter, who did not wish to be named, uses his "mobile office on wheels" to work while his chauffeur drives him to factory visits and client meetings.

For decades, India's wealthy chose the comfort of luxury sedans as they headed to work. Then came the SUVs (sport utility vehicles), which offered better road presence, a higher seating position and enough ground clearance to navigate potholed roads. While both luxury sedans and SUVs continue to be in demand, a radical shift is unfolding at the top end of India's luxury car market: the country's elite are increasingly trading even their high-riding SUVs for ultra-luxury MPVs.

Reclining ottoman seats, fold-out tray tables, privacy partitions, HDMI port connectivity and conference-call-ready cabins are turning vehicles like the Toyota Vellfire and Mercedes-Benz V-Class, among others, into produc-

tivity pods for busy executives.

Luxury MPVs are clearly emerging as a fast-growing segment, indicating an early structural shift within India's car market. Their volumes rose sharply from 1,061 units in FY24 to 4,061 units in FY26, while their share expanded from 2.3% to 7.2%, signalling rapid adoption, according to data from JATO Dynamics. In contrast, sedans' share has dipped from 34.16% to 28.92% over the same period and they are growing slowly, while SUVs remain dominant but relatively stable.

Japan's Toyota was the first carmaker to taste success with its Vellfire in India after a spate of Bollywood celebs opted for the luxury MPV. "With expansive interiors, superior ride comfort,